

negative to a positive one.

With the passage of time along with making consistent payments that are never late, you can improve your credit report. Most late payments will drop off after two years, with the exceptions of major blemishes like write-offs, reposessions, judgments, or foreclosures which stay on for up to seven years. In the case of Chapter 7 bankruptcy, the negative mark stays on your credit report for ten years.

It is a good idea to check your credit report at least once a year, or right before a major purchase is planned, for any inaccuracies. You can easily order credit reports online through [www.annualcreditreport.com](http://www.annualcreditreport.com) or by calling (877) 322-8228. You are entitled to one free credit report annually. The three major credit bureaus that compile your credit information are:

- Experian: (888) 397-3742; <http://www.experian.com>
- Equifax: (800) 685-1111; <http://www.equifax.com>
- Transunion: (800) 888-4213; <http://www.transunion.com>

Any time you are turned down for credit, you are supposed to be notified of the reason your request was rejected. There have been situations reported where information was merged for people that had the same name, or stolen credit card numbers were being used by another individual. For these reasons, it is a good idea to check regularly and make sure the information that is being reported is accurate.

## **A Fresh Start**

Once negative information is reported to a credit bureau, it may take up to seven years until it is purged from the system. This is a long time for such powerful data to remain a part of your records. Since only negative information that was

